

## Chapter Six

### Contemporary Global Issues

Contemporary global issues are issues which are currently capturing the agenda of world leaders, international media and institutions. By their nature contemporary global issues are dynamic: they change from time to time. Though some issues could be common for all generations, what was a contemporary global issue before some years back may not necessarily be a contemporary global issue today. Contemporary global issues are also trans-boundary issues. Their effects cannot be restrained within a boundary of a single state. They cannot be solved by the efforts of one state; rather they are addressed through collaborative effort among world countries. They are the concern of all nations.

Contemporary global issues are related with economy, security, health, environment, human rights and etc. The most common global issues include international trade, poverty and inequality, debt relief, communicable diseases, human rights, globalization, terrorism, armed conflicts, nuclear weapon, drug trafficking, migration, transnational corruption, climate change and sustainable energy. We will discuss some of them here under:

#### 6.1. Globalization

The term globalization is a comprehensive term which denotes the emergence of a global society in which economic, political, environmental, and cultural events in one part of the world quickly come to have significance for people in other parts of the world. Globalization is the result of advances in communication, transportation, and information technologies. It describes the growing economic, political, technological, and cultural linkages that connect individuals, communities, businesses, and governments around the world.

Although most people continue to live as citizens of a single nation, they are culturally, materially, and psychologically engaged with the lives of people in other countries as never before. Distant events often have an immediate and significant impact, blurring the boundaries of our personal worlds. Items common to our everyday lives—such as the clothes we wear, the food we eat, and the cars we drive—are the products of globalization.

Globalization has both negative and positive aspects. Among the negative aspects are the rapid spread of diseases, illicit drugs, crime, terrorism, and uncontrolled migration. Among globalization's benefits are a sharing of basic knowledge, technology, investments, resources, and ethical values.

Most experts attribute globalization to improvements in communication, transportation, and information technologies. The Internet, the cell phone, and the fax machine permit instantaneous communication. The World Wide Web and computers that store vast amounts of data allow instant access to information exceeding that of any library.

Improvements in transportation are also part of globalization. The world becomes smaller due to next-day delivery by jet airplane. Even slow, oceangoing vessels have streamlined transportation and lowered costs due to innovations such as containerized shipping. Advances in information technologies have also lowered business costs.

Not only do goods, money, and information move great distances quickly, but also more people are moving great distances as well. Migration, both legal and illegal, is a major feature of this era of globalization. *Remittances* (money sent home by workers to their home countries) have become an important source of income for many countries.

Some critics of globalization believe that aspects of the way globalization operates should be changed. The debate over globalization is about what the best rules are for governing the global economy so that its advantages can grow while its problems can be solved. On one side of this debate are those who stress the benefits of removing barriers to international trade and investment, allowing capital to be allocated more efficiently and giving consumers greater freedom of choice. With free-market globalization, investment funds can move unimpeded from where they are plentiful (the rich countries) to where they are most needed (the developing countries). Consumers can benefit from cheaper products because reduced tariffs make goods produced at low cost from faraway places cheaper to buy. Producers of goods gain by selling to a wider market. More competition keeps sellers on their toes and allows ideas and new technology to spread and benefit others. On the other side of the debate are critics who see neoliberal policies as producing greater poverty, inequality, social conflict, cultural destruction,

and environmental damage. They say that the most developed nations—the United States, Germany, and Japan—succeeded not because of free trade but because of protectionism and subsidies. They argue that the more recently successful economies of South Korea, Taiwan, and China all had strong state-led development strategies that did not follow neo-liberalism. These critics think that government encouragement of “infant industries”—that is, industries that are just beginning to develop—enable a country to become internationally competitive.

Furthermore, those who criticize the Washington Consensus suggest that the inflow and outflow of money from speculative investors must be limited to prevent *bubbles*. These bubbles are characterized by the rapid inflow of foreign funds that bid up domestic stock markets and property values. When the economy cannot sustain such expectations, the bubbles burst as investors panic and pull their money out of the country. These bubbles have happened repeatedly as liberalization has allowed speculation of this sort to get out of hand, such as in Indonesia, Malaysia, and Thailand in 1997 and since then in Argentina, Russia, and Turkey. According to critics, a strong active government is needed to assure stability and economic development.

Protests by what is called the anti-globalization movement are seldom directed against globalization itself but rather against abuses that harm the rights of workers and the environment. The question raised by nongovernmental organizations and protesters at WTO and IMF gatherings is whether globalization will result in a rise of living standards or a race to the bottom as competition takes the form of lowering living standards and undermining environmental regulation. One of the key problems of the 21st century will be determining to what extent markets should be regulated to promote fair competition, honest dealings, and fair distribution of public goods on a global scale.

### **6.2. Terrorism**

Terrorism is commonly understood to refer to acts of violence that target civilians in the pursuit of political or ideological aims. Although the international community has yet to adopt a comprehensive definition of terrorism, in 1994, the General Assembly’s Declaration on Measures to Eliminate International Terrorism, in its resolution 49/60, stated that terrorism includes “criminal acts intended or calculated to provoke a state of terror in the general public, a

group of persons or particular persons for political purposes” and that such acts “are in any circumstances unjustifiable, whatever the considerations of a political, philosophical, ideological, racial, ethnic, religious or other nature that may be invoked to justify them.” Terrorism has occurred throughout history for a variety of reasons. Its causes can be historical, cultural, political, social, psychological, economic, or religious—or any combination of these. Some countries have proven to be particularly susceptible to terrorism at certain times, as Italy and West Germany were during the 1970s.

In general, democratic countries have provided more fertile ground for terrorism because of the open nature of their societies. In such societies citizens have fundamental rights, civil liberties are legally protected, and government control and constant surveillance of its citizens and their activities is absent. By the same token, repressive societies, in which the government closely monitors citizens and restricts their speech and movement, have often provided more difficult environments for terrorists. But even police states have not been immune to terrorism, despite limiting civil liberties and forbidding free speech and rights of assembly. Examples include Russia as well as the People's Republic of China.

In broad terms the causes that have commonly compelled people to engage in terrorism are grievances borne of political oppression, cultural domination, economic exploitation, ethnic discrimination, and religious persecution. Perceived inequities in the distribution of wealth and political power have led some terrorists to attempt to overthrow governments. Some terrorists are motivated by very specific issues, such as opposition to legalized abortion or nuclear energy, or the championing of environmental concerns and animal rights. They hope to pressure both the public and its representatives in government to enact legislation directly reflecting their particular concern. Militant animal rights activists, for example, have used violence against scientists and laboratory technicians in their campaign to halt medical experimentation involving animals. Radical environmentalists have sabotaged logging operations and the construction of power grids to protest the spoiling of natural wilderness areas. Extremists who oppose legalized abortion in the United States have attacked clinics and murdered doctors and other employees in hopes of denying women the right to abortion.

---

National governments have at times aided terrorists to further their own foreign policy goals. So-called state-sponsored terrorism, however, falls into a different category altogether. State-sponsored terrorism is a form of covert (secret) warfare, a means to wage war secretly through the use of terrorist surrogates (stand-ins) as hired guns. The U.S. Department of State designates countries as state sponsors of terrorism if they actively assist or aid terrorists, and also if they harbor past terrorists or refuse to renounce terrorism as an instrument of policy. State sponsorship has proven invaluable to some terrorist organizations—by supplying arms, money, and a safe haven, among other things. In doing so, it has transformed ordinary groups, with otherwise limited capabilities, into more powerful and menacing opponents. State sponsorship can also place at terrorists' disposal the resources of an established country's diplomatic, military, and intelligence services. These services improve the training of terrorists and facilitate planning and operations. Finally, governments have paid terrorists handsomely for their services. They thereby turn weak and financially impoverished groups into formidable, well-endowed terrorist organizations with an ability to attract recruits.

Bombing historically has been the most common terrorist tactic. Armed attacks historically rank as the second most-common terrorist tactic, followed by more complex operations such as assassination of heads of state or other well-protected people, kidnapping, hostage taking, and hijacking.

### **Impact of Terrorism**

Although most terrorist groups have failed to achieve their long-term strategic aims through terrorism, terrorism has occasionally brought about significant political changes that might otherwise have been impossible. Moreover, despite the claims of governments to the contrary, terrorism has sometimes also proven successful on a short-term, tactical level: winning the release of prisoners, wresting political concessions from otherwise resistant governments, or ensuring that causes and grievances that might otherwise have been ignored or neglected were addressed.

---

Terrorism was used by some nationalist movements in the anticolonial era just after World War II, when British and French empires in Africa, Asia, and the Middle East dissolved. Countries as diverse as Israel, Cyprus, Kenya, and Algeria owe their independence to these movements.

Evidence of terrorist success has come more recently in the examples of Gerry Adams and Martin McGuinness in Northern Ireland and Yasir Arafat in the Middle East. Adams, president of the political wing of the Irish Republican Army (IRA) in Northern Ireland, and his deputy McGuinness both won election to the British Parliament in 1997. Arafat, as leader of the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), won international recognition for the PLO. Through tactical victories and political achievements, each of their organizations demonstrated how a series of terrorist acts can propel to world attention long-standing causes and grievances.

At the same time, for every terrorist success, there are the countless failures. Most terrorist groups never achieve any of their aims—either short-term or long-term. The life span of most modern terrorist groups underscores this failure. According to one estimate, the life expectancy of at least 90 percent of terrorist organizations is less than a year, and nearly half of the organizations that make it that far cease to exist within a decade of their founding.

Terrorism is designed to threaten the personal safety of its target audience. It can tear apart the social fabric of a country by destroying business and cultural life and the mutual trust upon which society is based. Uncertainty about where and when the next terrorist attack will occur generates a fear that terrorism experts call “vicarious victimization.” A common response to this fear is the refusal to visit shopping malls; attend sporting events; go to the theater, movies, or concerts; or travel, either abroad or within one’s own country.

The public's perception of personal risk, however, often does not dovetail with the observable dimensions of the terrorist threat. Even though the United States was the country most frequently targeted by terrorists from 1968 to 2000, fewer than 1,000 Americans were killed by terrorists, either in the United States or abroad, during that 32-year period, according to figures tabulated by the U.S. State Department and the Federal Bureau of Investigation. Although more than three times that number was killed on September 11, 2001, the fact remains that the perception of the terrorist threat far outweighs the likelihood of being the victim of a terrorist attack. Nonetheless,

terrorism's ability to engender so acute sense of fear and unease is a measure of its impact on our daily life.

---

### **6.3. Environmental Challenges**

Though the environmental challenges on human life goes back as long as the existence of man on earth, the response towards the problem has cropped up of late only in the decades of 20<sup>th</sup> century. Environmental problems led to the world's first environmental conference in 1972 in Stockholm. The most significant product of the conference was the creation of the UN Environmental Program UNEP, which was to act as midwife to safeguard the global environment. Some of the major global strategies in dealing with these problems are contained in the multilateral environmental agreements such as ozone depletion, global warming and desertification. The big progress is that states have come to a recognition that they have to act more collaboratively at the international level in order to search for effective solutions to environmental problems.

It should be mentioned here that the development of a sense of shared vulnerability to environmental threats on the part of states and the catalytic and coordinative role of United Nations Environmental Program (UNEP), however, has faced a number of debilitating responses from the states. The shared vulnerability is due to the fact that the problem brought about in view of sheer neglect to the environment by the states-whether belonging to the Northern hemisphere or the Southern hemisphere-has a drastic impact on all states all over the world. This is due to the fact that states respond to continuing environmental challenges based upon their national interests.

Consequently, insufficient contributions by governments to environmental fund, insufficient authority and legitimacy of UNEP, collective disintegration and other factors in general have sadly produced a desperate impact on UNEP in addressing sufficiently the continuously deteriorating global environment.

### **6.4. Corruption**

The New Webster's Dictionary of the English Language International Edition (1995:219) has several definitions of the word corruption. These meanings comprise the following: "corruption is the state of being or becoming decayed, a spoiling, deteriorating, the corruption of taste by cheap journalism corrupt practices perversion, moral decay, a corrupting influence, a debased form of a word".

"Corrupt practice" "perversion" "moral decay" and a "corrupting influence" are all part of the negative effects which corruption has on any society where widespread corruption is practiced. There can be no doubt that a process; phenomenon or institution that suffers from corrupting influences is likely to

become decayed or to fall into a state of decay or perversion. Thus all the meanings given to the word corruption have some relevance in any discussion of economic and political corruption.

Corruption is the abuse of public institutions for private gain. Corruption is detrimental to both the economic and the political well-being of countries. Corruption increases inequality by harming the poor and benefiting the few with access to the powerful. Corruption occurs not only at a national level but also at the international level. International corruption is committed by individuals, multinational companies, governmental and non-governmental institutions; especially, through the inappropriate use of foreign aid and investment. Different government leaders are also sometimes involved in such acts and save their illegal money in major banks outside of their country.

## **6.5. International migration**

Increasing flows of people across national borders are both a contributor to and a consequence of a more interconnected world. Usually migration takes place from economically poor countries into relatively rich countries or from politically unstable countries into politically stable countries.

Although, the largest economic gains from immigration accrue to the immigrants themselves, the international migration of labor can also benefit both the countries receiving immigrants and the countries sending them, and that on balance it boosts world income and reduces poverty. In the receiving countries, migrants can fill labor shortages in certain industries. In the sending countries, they can help ease unemployment and other social pressures while increasing financial inflows, in the form of **remittances** from migrants to their families back home. Remittances also help level out the distribution of income both within and across countries.

Migration is not without its costs, actually. For the migrants themselves, the journey itself and the search for fair employment and humane treatment in the host country can be arduous and risky. The host country government may bear added costs to assimilate the migrants, and wages for some native workers may fall. The home country may suffer a loss of valuable skilled workers.

## **Forces Shaping Today's Global Issues**

The evolution of global issues in the coming years will be shaped by many factors. The forces driving these issues, the consequences thereof, and the appropriate solutions vary from issue to issue but certain broad forces are common to many of them. These include:

1. Demography (the number of world population is increasing from time to time which has both positive and negative ramifications)
2. Growth of the global economy (the world economy is increasing while world resources are decreasing. This has too positive and negative consequences)
3. Scientific and technological innovations (different innovations like nuclear weapon can positively and negatively affect those global issues)
4. Increasing interconnectedness and interdependence (global interdependence or globalization have positive and negative consequences)
5. Global advocacy (civil societies and advocacy groups also shape those global issues)

## **How are Today's Global Issues being addressed?**

Unless those global issues are properly addressed, they will have, interalia, economic, health, security, and environment related consequences. It is known that there is no world government to address these global issues. They are being addressed through collective action by efforts of world countries, different institutions and individuals. This collective action is expressed in the form of:

1. International agreements signed by both industrial and developing countries
2. International Law
3. Declarations signed by participants at international conferences
4. Actions of the G-8, G-20, G-77 and other such groupings.
5. Civil society campaigns and associations
6. Global partnerships
7. Global governance institutions like IMF and WB